

CSS Text-Overflow

Complete Guide: Handling Text That Doesn't Fit

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1 Introduction

The CSS `text-overflow` property specifies how overflowing text should be displayed when it exceeds container boundaries. Combined with `overflow` and `white-space`, it provides elegant solutions for handling text that doesn't fit.

1.1 The Overflow Problem

When text exceeds a container's width:

- Text may overflow unpredictably
- Layout becomes broken
- User experience suffers
- Important content may be hidden
- Mobile layouts become problematic

1.2 text-overflow Solutions

The `text-overflow` property provides three approaches:

- **clip:** Cut off text abruptly
- **ellipsis:** Show "..." at the end
- **Custom string:** Show custom character

2 text-overflow Property Values

2.1 Available Values

Value	Behavior	Display
clip	Truncate at edge	No indicator
ellipsis	Show dots	"..."
string	Custom text	Custom character

2.2 Requirements for text-overflow

For `text-overflow` to work, you must also set:

1. `overflow: hidden` (or `auto/scroll`)
2. `white-space: nowrap` (for single line)
3. Fixed width or `max-width`

3 text-overflow: clip

The default value. Text is cut off at the container edge.

3.1 Behavior

- Text truncates without indicator
- No visual cue that text is hidden
- Abrupt cutoff at edge
- Rarely used (ellipsis preferred)

3.2 Examples

```
/* Explicit clip (usually default) */
p {
  width: 200px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: clip;
  white-space: nowrap;
}

/* Result: "This is a very long text" becomes "This is a very lo" */
```

4 text-overflow: ellipsis

Shows "..." when text overflows. Most common and user-friendly option.

4.1 Behavior

- Adds “...” at end of text
- Visually indicates truncation
- User knows content is hidden
- Professional appearance
- Works with single-line text

4.2 Single-Line Ellipsis

```
/* Basic ellipsis */
p {
  width: 200px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}

/* Result: "This is a very long text..." */

/* Table cell */
td {
  max-width: 150px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}

/* Link */
a {
  display: block;
  width: 300px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}

/* File path */
.filepath {
  width: 400px;
  font-family: monospace;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}
```

4.3 Multi-Line Ellipsis

For multiple lines, use `line-clamp` instead:

```
/* Truncate at 3 lines */
.description {
  display: -webkit-box;
  -webkit-line-clamp: 3;
  -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
}

/* Alternative modern approach */
.text-truncate {
  max-height: 4.5em; /* 3 lines × 1.5 line-height */
  line-height: 1.5;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  display: -webkit-box;
  -webkit-line-clamp: 3;
  -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
}

/* Fade effect */
.fade-truncate {
  max-height: 4.5em;
  overflow: hidden;
  position: relative;
}

.fade-truncate::after {
  content: '';
  position: absolute;
  bottom: 0;
  left: 0;
  right: 0;
  height: 1.5em;
  background: linear-gradient(transparent, white);
}
```

5 Custom text-overflow String

Use a custom character or string for overflow indicator.

5.1 Syntax

```
text-overflow: '>>>'; /* Custom string */
text-overflow: '...'; /* Custom ellipsis */
text-overflow: →''; /* Arrow indicator */
```

5.2 Browser Support

Custom strings have limited browser support. Recommended for modern browsers or with fallbacks.

5.3 Examples

```
/* Custom string (modern browsers) */
p {
  width: 200px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: '>>>';
  white-space: nowrap;
}

/* With fallback */
p {
  width: 200px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  text-overflow: →''; /* Modern browsers use this */
  white-space: nowrap;
}

/* Arrow indicator */
.truncated {
  width: 300px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ↓'';
  white-space: nowrap;
}

/* Multiple characters */
.custom {
  width: 250px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: '[+]';
  white-space: nowrap;
}
```

6 Real-World Use Cases

6.1 Use Case 1: Table Cells

```
/* Truncate long table content */
td {
  max-width: 150px;
  padding: 8px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}

/* Specific column */
td.description {
  max-width: 300px;
}

/* With title attribute for full text */
<td title="Full description text...">
  Truncated text...
</td>

/* Styled table */
table {
  width: 100%;
  border-collapse: collapse;
}

th, td {
  border: 1px solid #ddd;
  padding: 8px;
  text-align: left;
}

td {
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}
```

6.2 Use Case 2: File Path Display

```
.filepath {
  font-family: monospace;
  background-color: #f4f4f4;
  padding: 8px 12px;
  border-radius: 4px;
  width: 100%;
  max-width: 500px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
}
```



```
    white-space: nowrap;
}

/* With icon */
.filepath::before {
    content: ' ';
    margin-right: 5px;
}

/* Breadcrumb */
.breadcrumb {
    max-width: 600px;
    overflow: hidden;
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
    white-space: nowrap;
}
```

6.3 Use Case 3: Username/Email

```
.username {
    max-width: 200px;
    overflow: hidden;
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
    white-space: nowrap;
}

.email {
    max-width: 300px;
    font-family: monospace;
    overflow: hidden;
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
    white-space: nowrap;
}

/* Profile card */
.profile-card {
    width: 250px;
}

.profile-card .name {
    font-size: 18px;
    font-weight: 600;
    overflow: hidden;
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
    white-space: nowrap;
}

.profile-card .email {
    font-size: 14px;
    color: #666;
    overflow: hidden;
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
    white-space: nowrap;
}
```

```
}
```

6.4 Use Case 4: Product Title/Description

```
.product-title {
  font-size: 18px;
  font-weight: 600;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}

.product-description {
  display: -webkit-box;
  -webkit-line-clamp: 2;
  -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  line-height: 1.4;
  height: 2.8em;
}

/* E-commerce card */
.product-card {
  width: 250px;
  padding: 15px;
  border: 1px solid #ddd;
  border-radius: 8px;
}

.product-card .title {
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
  margin-bottom: 10px;
}

.product-card .desc {
  display: -webkit-box;
  -webkit-line-clamp: 3;
  -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
}
```

6.5 Use Case 5: Chat Messages

```
.message {
  max-width: 400px;
  padding: 10px 15px;
  border-radius: 8px;
}
```

```
    background-color: #e3f2fd;
}

.message-text {
    word-wrap: break-word;
    overflow-wrap: break-word;
}

/* URL in message */
.message a {
    display: block;
    color: #0066cc;
    overflow: hidden;
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
    white-space: nowrap;
    text-decoration: underline;
}

/* Long username */
.message-sender {
    font-weight: 600;
    max-width: 250px;
    overflow: hidden;
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
    white-space: nowrap;
}
```

7 Combining Properties

7.1 text-overflow with overflow

```
/* Must use with overflow: hidden */
p {
    overflow: hidden;
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
    white-space: nowrap;
}

/* Or overflow: auto for scrollable */
code {
    max-width: 400px;
    overflow: auto; /* Can scroll instead */
    white-space: pre;
}

/* Or overflow: scroll */
.scrollable {
    width: 300px;
    overflow: scroll;
    text-overflow: clip; /* Not visible with scroll */
}
```

7.2 text-overflow with white-space

```
/* Single line (required for ellipsis) */
.single-line {
  white-space: nowrap;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
}

/* Multi-line (use line-clamp) */
.multi-line {
  display: -webkit-box;
  -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
  -webkit-line-clamp: 3;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
}

/* Pre-formatted */
pre {
  white-space: pre;
  overflow-x: auto;
  text-overflow: clip;
}
```

7.3 text-overflow with width

```
/* Fixed width */
.fixed {
  width: 200px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
}

/* Max-width */
.flexible {
  max-width: 300px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
}

/* Percentage width */
.percent {
  width: 50%;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
}

/* With padding */
.padded {
  width: 200px;
  padding: 10px;
  overflow: hidden;
}
```

```

    text-overflow: ellipsis;
    white-space: nowrap;
    box-sizing: border-box; /* Important! */
}
\end{lstlisting}

\newpage

\section{Multi-Line Text Truncation}

Truncate text to multiple lines instead of just one.

\subsection{line-clamp Method}

\begin{lstlisting}
/* Truncate to 3 lines */
.text-3-lines {
    display: -webkit-box;
    -webkit-line-clamp: 3;
    -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
    overflow: hidden;
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
}

/* Truncate to 2 lines */
.text-2-lines {
    display: -webkit-box;
    -webkit-line-clamp: 2;
    -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
    overflow: hidden;
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
}

/* Dynamic line clamping */
.text-clamp-4 {
    display: -webkit-box;
    -webkit-line-clamp: 4;
    -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
    overflow: hidden;
}

```

7.4 Height-Based Truncation

```

/* Using height instead of line-clamp */
.text-truncate {
    max-height: 4.5em; /* 3 lines × 1.5em */
    line-height: 1.5em;
    overflow: hidden;
    position: relative;
}

/* Add fade effect */
.text-truncate::after {

```

```

content: '';
position: absolute;
bottom: 0;
left: 0;
right: 0;
height: 1.5em;
background: linear-gradient(transparent, white);
pointer-events: none;
}

```

8 Browser Support

8.1 text-overflow Support

Feature	Chrome	Firefox	Safari	Edge
clip	All	All	All	All
ellipsis	All	All	All	All
Custom string	90+	90+	15.4+	90+
-webkit-line-clamp	All	68+	All	All

8.2 Fallback Strategies

```

/* Provide fallback for older browsers */
p {
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  text-overflow: '>>>'; /* Custom, ignored if unsupported */
  white-space: nowrap;
}

/* Feature detection */
@supports (text-overflow: '>>>') {
  p {
    text-overflow: '>>>';
  }
}

@supports not (text-overflow: '>>>') {
  p {
    text-overflow: ellipsis;
  }
}

```

9 Accessibility Considerations

9.1 Best Practices

- Provide full text in title attribute
- Use aria-label for important content

- Test with screen readers
- Ensure truncation doesn't hide critical info
- Consider showing full text on hover

9.2 Accessible Examples

```
/* Include title for full text */
<p class="truncated" title="Full text here...">
  Truncated text...
</p>

/* With aria-label */
<span class="truncated" aria-label="Full description">
  Description...
</span>

/* Show full text on hover */
.truncated {
  max-width: 200px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}

.truncated:hover::after {
  content: ' (full text: ' attr(title) ')';
}

/* Link to full content */
<a href="/full-article" class="truncated">
  Article title...
</a>
```

10 Common Issues and Solutions

10.1 Issue 1: Ellipsis Not Showing

Problem:

```
.text {
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  /* Missing overflow: hidden */
}
```

Solution:

```
.text {
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}
```

10.2 Issue 2: Width Not Working

Problem:

```
p {
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  /* No fixed width */
}
```

Solution:

```
p {
  width: 200px; /* Or max-width */
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}
```

10.3 Issue 3: Wrapping Text

Problem:

```
p {
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  /* Text still wraps */
}
```

Solution:

```
p {
  white-space: nowrap; /* Prevent wrapping */
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
}
```

10.4 Issue 4: Line-Clamp Not Working

Problem:

```
.text {
  -webkit-line-clamp: 3;
  /* Missing display and orientation */
}
```

Solution:

```
.text {
  display: -webkit-box;
  -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
  -webkit-line-clamp: 3;
  overflow: hidden;
}
```


11 Advanced Techniques

11.1 Hover to Show Full Text

```
.truncated {
  width: 200px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
  cursor: pointer;
}

.truncated::after {
  content: '...';
}

.truncated:hover {
  overflow: visible;
  white-space: normal;
  background-color: #f0f0f0;
  padding: 10px;
  position: absolute;
  z-index: 1;
}

.truncated:hover::after {
  content: '';
}
```

11.2 Tooltip on Truncation

```
.truncated {
  position: relative;
}

.truncated:hover .tooltip {
  display: block;
  position: absolute;
  background-color: #333;
  color: white;
  padding: 8px 12px;
  border-radius: 4px;
  white-space: normal;
  z-index: 1;
}

/* HTML */
<span class="truncated">
  Very long text...
  <span class="tooltip">Very long text goes here</span>
</span>
```

11.3 Responsive Truncation

```
/* Desktop */
@media (min-width: 1024px) {
  .title {
    width: 300px;
  }
}

/* Tablet */
@media (max-width: 1023px) and (min-width: 768px) {
  .title {
    width: 250px;
  }
}

/* Mobile */
@media (max-width: 767px) {
  .title {
    width: 100%;
    max-width: 200px;
  }
}
```

12 Performance Considerations

12.1 Performance Impact

- text-overflow has minimal performance cost
- -webkit-line-clamp may affect layout
- Multiple truncated elements: negligible impact
- No performance penalty from ellipsis

13 Summary: Key Takeaways

13.1 text-overflow Values

Value	Behavior	Use
clip	Cut off text	Rarely used
ellipsis	Show dots	Most common
string	Custom text	Modern browsers

13.2 Required Properties

For text-overflow to work:

1. `overflow: hidden` (required)
2. `white-space: nowrap` (for single line)

3. Fixed or max-width (required)

13.3 Best Practices

1. Use `ellipsis` for user-friendly truncation
2. Always set `overflow: hidden`
3. Provide full text in `title` attribute
4. Use `line-clamp` for multi-line truncation
5. Test on different screen sizes
6. Consider accessibility
7. Provide hover tooltips for truncated content
8. Use fixed or max-width with box-sizing
9. Test across browsers
10. Don't rely on truncation alone for important info

13.4 Quick Reference

```
/* Single line with ellipsis */
.truncated {
  width: 200px;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}

/* Multi-line truncation */
.text-clamp-3 {
  display: -webkit-box;
  -webkit-line-clamp: 3;
  -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
}

/* With title for accessibility */
<div class="truncated" title="Full text">
  Truncated...
</div>

/* Responsive truncation */
.responsive {
  max-width: 100%;
  overflow: hidden;
  text-overflow: ellipsis;
  white-space: nowrap;
}
```

```
}  
  
@media (max-width: 768px) {  
  .responsive {  
    max-width: 150px;  
  }  
}
```

14 Conclusion

The CSS `text-overflow` property is essential for creating user-friendly, professional web interfaces. Combined with `overflow` and `white-space`, it provides elegant solutions for handling text that exceeds container boundaries.

Key principles to remember:

1. Use `ellipsis` for user-friendly truncation
2. Always set `overflow: hidden`
3. Provide full text via title or tooltip
4. Use line-clamp for multiple lines
5. Test responsive behavior on all devices
6. Consider accessibility implications
7. Avoid hiding critical information through truncation
8. Combine with other properties for flexibility
9. Provide visual feedback (hover states, tooltips)
10. Use appropriate fallbacks for older browsers

With mastery of text-overflow, you'll create professional, polished interfaces that gracefully handle text of any length while maintaining excellent user experience and accessibility.

Happy coding!